

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Data: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2023) | Source: Our World in Data

For public health policy analysts and mental health program planners

Hundreds of Millions Affected Every Year

Lifetime risk of major depression is strikingly high — and mental health conditions span from common to severe.

1 in 3

WOMEN

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

1 in 5

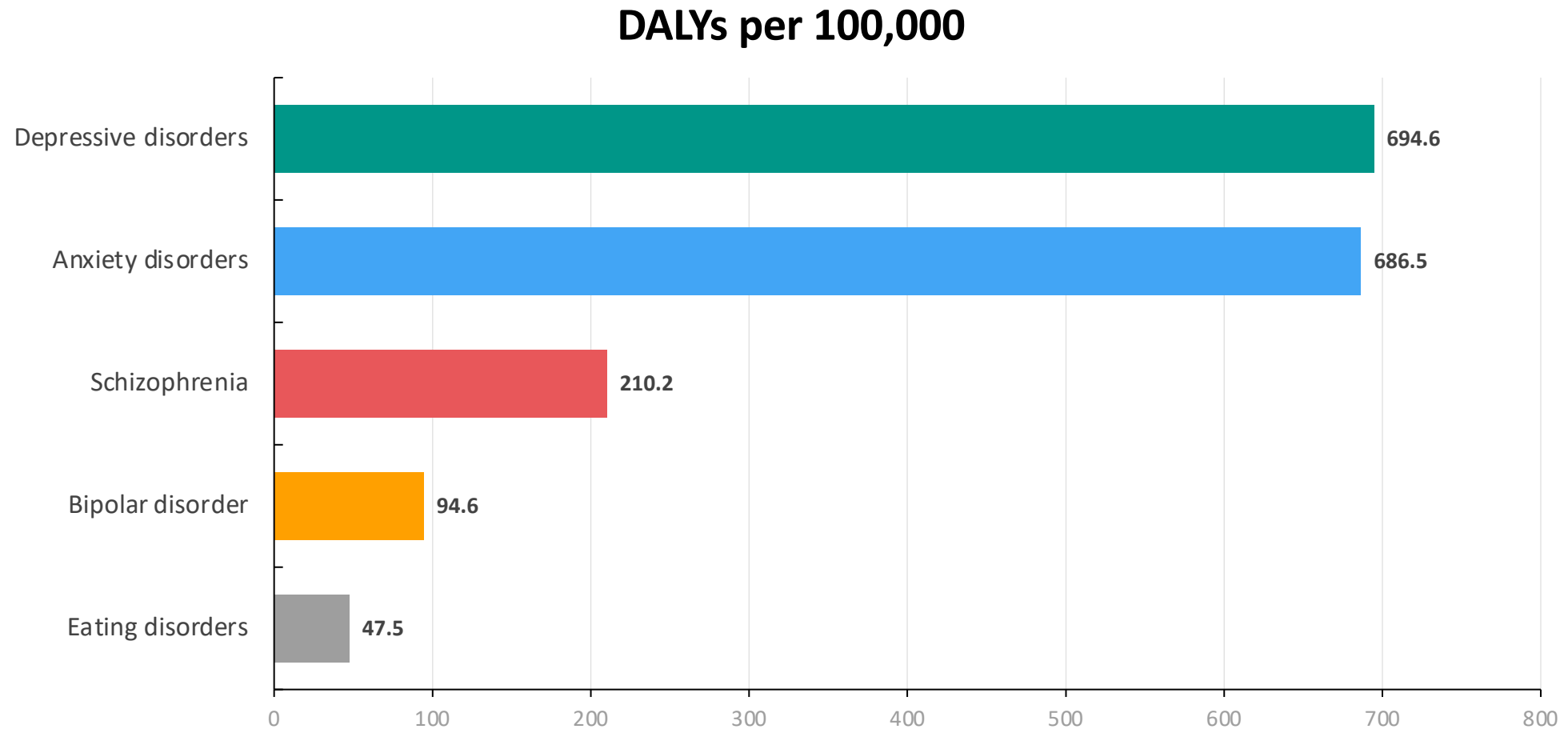
MEN

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

Other conditions — schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, eating disorders — are less common but carry severe individual impact.

Disease Burden by Mental Illness Category

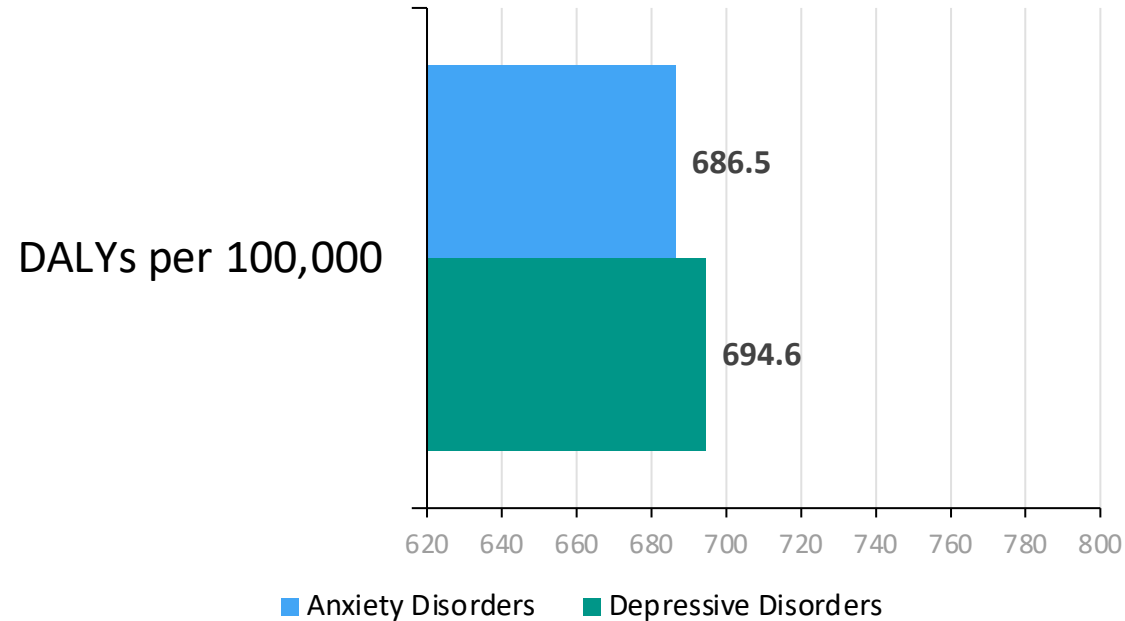
DALYs per 100,000 people | World, 2023



Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2023) via Our World in Data

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Burden

Together they account for ~80% of the total mental health disease burden across five major categories.



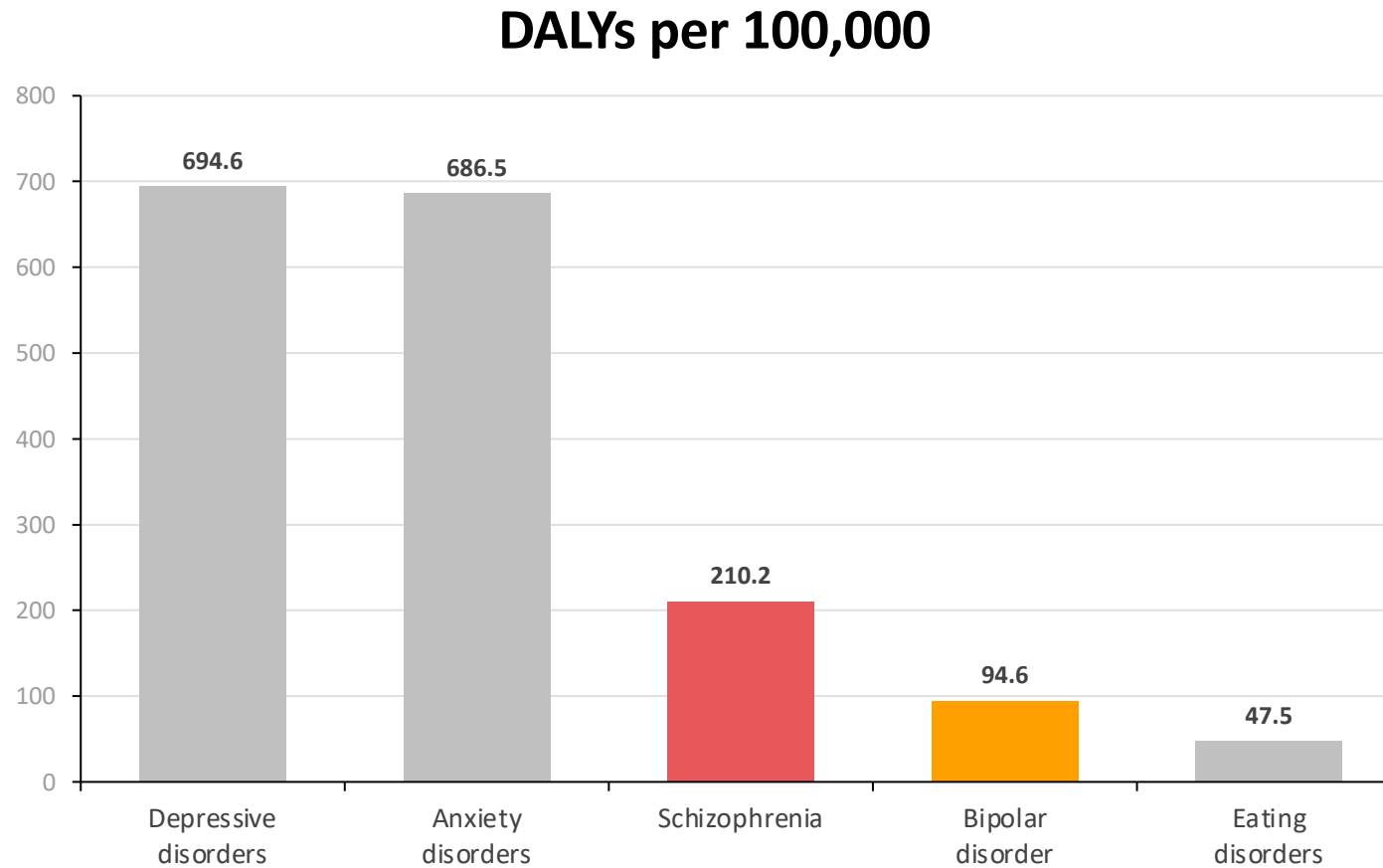
~80%

of total mental health DALYs
come from depression and
anxiety combined

Policy implication: Interventions targeting depression and anxiety will address the majority of the population-level mental health burden.

Schizophrenia & Bipolar: Lower Prevalence, Severe Individual Impact

While fewer people are affected, the disability per person is disproportionately high.



Schizophrenia

210.2 DALYs / 100K

Reflects severe, lasting disability
despite lower prevalence

Bipolar Disorder

94.6 DALYs / 100K

Smaller population burden but
significant individual impact

Treatment Is Available — But Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced. Yet significant barriers persist.



STIGMA

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know.



ACCESS

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



QUALITY

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality — failing to meet clinical standards.



UNDERREPORTING

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence — the actual burden may be higher than reported.

Good data is essential to understand these conditions — how, when, and why they occur, how many people are affected, and how they can be treated effectively and safely.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family

Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression.



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings. Pharmaceutical interventions remain a primary clinical response.



Religious / Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide. Faith-based coping is a major resource across diverse cultures.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism. Social support networks play a critical role in mental health resilience.

Policy interventions must account for cultural, economic, and healthcare system differences — a one-size-fits-all approach will not work.

Key Takeaways for Policy Action

1

Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — each generating ~690 DALYs per 100,000 people.

2

Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden despite lower population-level prevalence.

3

Effective treatments exist, but access and quality remain inadequate — especially in low- and middle-income countries.

4

Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data, meaning the true burden is likely underestimated.

5

Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.